THE INVESTOR'S GUIDE

Marsa Al Saadiyat

The final beachfront district of Saadiyat Island - read before the price sheets exist.

AT THE UNVEILING · SAADIYAT ISLAND · AUGUST 2026

Abu Dhabi · Master developer: Aldar · Delivery 2030-2033

Prepared by Calum MacLeod · White & Co · @uaecalum
Off-plan specialist, invested in what I recommend

Compiled from the masterplan unveiling plus published market data. Figures marked "estimate" are exactly that. Not financial advice.

FROM THE ROOM

The Unveiling, First-Hand

THE SCALE MODEL: RESORT-DENSITY VILLA FABRIC BEHIND 8 KM OF COASTLINE - A QUARTER OF THE DENSITY OF CENTRAL DUBAI MASTERPLANS

THE 350-BERTH MARINA - ABU DHABI'S LARGEST, BUILT FOR 101 M SUPERYACHTS

DAR AL FANUN - GEHRY'S 6,000-SEAT HOUSE OF PERFORMING ARTS, ON THE WATER

SHOT FROM THE SITE ITSELF: THE CAPITAL'S SKYLINE ACROSS THE WATER - THE SECLUSION TRADE, VISIBLE

CHAPTER ONE

What Was Unveiled

Marsa Al Saadiyat - "Harbor of Happiness" - is the final chapter of Saadiyat Island: the last beachfront district on the capital's cultural island, unveiled as a fully self-sufficient community of luxury living, culture, wellness and education. When this is built out, Saadiyat's coastline is finished. There is no sequel.

744 ha 7.4M SQM MASTERPLAN	8 km OF COASTLINE	18,000 RESIDENCES	58,000 FUTURE RESIDENTS
3.8M sqm GROSS FLOOR AREA	129 ha GREEN SPACE · 73,800 SQM CENTRAL PARKS	350 MARINA BERTHS - AD'S LARGEST	2030-33 DELIVERY WINDOW

The shape of the place

A 1 km waterfront promenade of luxury F&B, retail and pedestrian-only zones. The district is engineered with **22.5 metres of landscape elevation so sea views run deep into the plan** - not just the front row. Density is resort-scale, not tower-scale: 18,000 homes across 744 hectares is roughly a quarter of the density of central Dubai masterplans.

The launch-event tell: representatives repeatedly noted that "many details cannot yet be disclosed" - no price sheets, no unit mixes, no plot releases. That's not a gap in this guide; it IS the opportunity. Everything in these pages is what can be known before the market is allowed to price it.

The Anchors

Dar al Fanun - the Gehry statement

The district is anchored by a **6,000-seat House of Performing Arts designed by Frank Gehry** - Broadway productions, opera, ballet. Gehry's Guggenheim Bilbao famously transformed a city's property market; Abu Dhabi is placing his next landmark inside a residential district it controls end-to-end.

The marina - AD's largest

350 berths including accommodation for 101-metre superyachts. Superyacht infrastructure is the hardest amenity to retrofit and the strongest UHNW magnet in real estate - berths of this class exist in a handful of addresses worldwide, and their presence anchors the top of the district's pricing forever.

The education stack

- **Two private schools, one public school, six nurseries** inside the district
- **NYU Abu Dhabi minutes away** - with studios and one-beds explicitly targeted at its community

The active grid

- **46 km of cycling tracks · 140 km of walking trails** - island-scale, not development-scale
- Tennis, basketball and padel courts · resort pools · wellness clubs with yoga, Pilates, private cabanas
- Sustainability to Amsterdam-modelled standards - native flora and fauna conserved (turtles, dolphins, deer)

The pattern to notice: every anchor - arts venue, superyacht marina, schools, NYU - is a **demand engine that exists independently of the property market.** Districts anchored by real institutions hold value differently from districts anchored by renders.

Why Saadiyat, Why Now - The Data

#1	+18.3%	+17.8%	84%
SAADIYAT = AD'S MOST EXPENSIVE DISTRICT	SAADIYAT APARTMENTS, PAST YEAR	ABU DHABI CITYWIDE, PAST YEAR	OF AD SALES ARE OFF-PLAN

Saadiyat already commands the capital's peak pricing: **apartments around Đ4,000/sqft and villas around Đ2,460/sqft** (ValuStrat, Q2 2026) - and it's still among the fastest-appreciating districts in the emirate at **+18.3% year-on-year for apartments**. This is the rare combination markets usually don't allow: the most expensive address AND near the highest growth.

The macro floor under it

Abu Dhabi's residential market rose **+17.8% in the past year** with off-plan capturing **84% of all transactions (+156% year-on-year)** - the capital's buyers have moved decisively to buying the future. ValuStrat's research head is on record that Abu Dhabi **sits earlier in its property cycle than Dubai** - the same run Dubai has already had, still in front of the capital.

> **And the date that matters: 11 December 2026.** The Guggenheim Abu Dhabi - the largest Guggenheim in the world - opens on Saadiyat, joining the Louvre, teamLab Phenomena, the Natural History Museum and the Zayed National Museum. The cultural district reaches completion in the exact window this masterplan comes to market. Districts don't get two of these moments.

Sources: ValuStrat Abu Dhabi Review Q2-2026; masterplan unveiling, August 2026. All growth figures are historical - not guarantees of future performance.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Cultural Ecosystem - Abu Dhabi's Moat

Marsa Al Saadiyat sits beside the **Saadiyat Cultural District**, the densest concentration of world-class institutions being built anywhere on earth:

INSTITUTION	STATUS
Louvre Abu Dhabi	Open since 2017
teamLab Phenomena	Open - immersive art
Natural History Museum Abu Dhabi	In delivery
Zayed National Museum (Foster + Partners)	In delivery
Guggenheim Abu Dhabi - the world's largest	**Opens 11 December 2026**

Why culture is the moat

Dubai can out-build almost anyone on towers, beaches and malls. What it cannot replicate is **five global museums on one island** - these institutions take decades of statecraft to assemble, and they anchor a kind of resident (and a kind of price) that pure leisure districts never capture. Culture is Abu Dhabi's structural advantage, and Saadiyat is where it's concentrated.

The global precedent is well documented - Bilbao's Guggenheim turned an industrial city into a destination economy, and museum-district completion from Paris to Hong Kong's West Kowloon has consistently re-rated the residential addresses beside it. Saadiyat is running that playbook with five institutions at once - and Marsa Al Saadiyat is the last residential land beside them.

The investor translation: when the Guggenheim's doors open in December, the world's cultural press will point every camera at this island. The masterplan's sales programme will be live in the same news cycle. That is not a coincidence; it's sequencing.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Connectivity Bet

Dubai in 45 minutes

The masterplan includes a **high-speed rail station connecting residents to Dubai in 45 minutes.** If delivered as planned, this single piece of infrastructure rewrites the geography of both cities: Saadiyat becomes commutable from DIFC, and Dubai's weekend economy becomes local to Saadiyat's beaches and museums.

Priced into today's market? Almost certainly not - rail projects get priced in twice: once on credible commitment, once on opening day. Buying beside a future station before either repricing is one of the oldest asymmetries in property.

Engineered views

The district's **22.5 metres of landscape elevation** means sea views penetrate deep into the plan rather than belonging only to the beachfront row - materially widening the pool of premium units, and narrowing the usual gap between front-row and second-ring pricing.

The seclusion trade

Saadiyat's quiet has always been both its luxury and its discount - serene, but "far" by Dubai standards. The rail link plus the completed cultural district attacks the discount from both directions while the serenity stays. That's the connectivity bet in one line: **keep the peace, lose the isolation.**

> Timing note: infrastructure timelines slip - treat the rail as upside, not baseline. Every number in this guide's models assumes ZERO value from the rail link. If it lands, it's free.

Where We Estimate It Prices

Aldar has released no pricing - **everything on this page is our estimate**, anchored to what Saadiyat trades at today (apartments ~Đ4,000/sqft, villas ~Đ2,460/sqft) and where recent island launches have opened relative to ready stock. New-launch beachfront masterplans typically open at a discount to the district's ready prime, then converge through the build.

EXPECTED PRODUCT	EST. SIZE	EST. LAUNCH PSF	EST. ENTRY
Studios & 1-beds (NYU / marina-district demand)	450-900 sqft	Đ2,800-3,600	Đ1.4M-3.2M
2-3 bed apartments, promenade & park districts	**1,100-2,200 sqft**	**Đ2,800-3,800**	**Đ3.2M-8M**
Townhouses & garden homes	2,500-3,500 sqft	Đ2,200-2,800	Đ6M-10M
Villas - inner rings	**4,000-6,500 sqft**	**Đ2,000-2,700**	**Đ8M-17M**
Beachfront / marina-front villas & signature	6,500-12,000+ sqft	Đ2,700-3,800+	Đ20M-45M+

Estimates, August 2026, before any official release - revised the day the first price sheet lands. Phase-one launches typically open at the bottom of these ranges; premiums stack for beach, marina and Gehry-view frontage.

Expected structure

Aldar's recent launches have favoured **construction-weighted plans around 60/40 with ~10% on booking**, plus Abu Dhabi's **2% registration fee** - so realistic day-one cash ≈ **12% of price**. On a Đ3M one-bed: ~Đ360,000 (~£77,000) to open. Materially lighter day-one cash than Dubai's 4% DLD market - one of the capital's quietest advantages.

The Numbers - Three Buys, Modelled

Three illustrative purchases on the assumed Aldar-typical plan (10% booking, 60% by handover, 40% on completion, +2% registration), held to a 2030 handover. Two growth cases each: **"last year's pace"** - Saadiyat's actual published growth (apartments +18.3%/yr, villas +12%/yr) compounded four years - and a deliberately conservative **"half pace"** case. Reality will choose its own number; the frame is what matters.

PURCHASE	GROWTH CASE	EST. HANDOVER VALUE	ROI (ON PRICE)	ROE (ON CASH)	IRR
Đ3M 1-bed	Last year's pace (+18.3%/yr)	Đ5.88M	+96%	+151%	~48%/yr
Đ3M 1-bed	Half pace (+9.2%/yr)	Đ4.26M	+42%	+64%	~25%/yr
Đ8M villa	Last year's pace (+12%/yr)	Đ12.59M	+57%	+89%	~33%/yr
Đ8M villa	Half pace (+6%/yr)	Đ10.10M	+26%	+39%	~17%/yr
Đ25M villa	Last year's pace (+12%/yr)	Đ39.34M	+57%	+89%	~33%/yr
Đ25M villa	Half pace (+6%/yr)	Đ31.56M	+26%	+39%	~17%/yr

How to read ROE: selling at handover, before the final 40% instalment, you've deployed ~62% of price - so price growth is amplified on your actual cash. That's the off-plan engine: staged capital, full-price growth. **IRR** annualises it across the staged payments - even the conservative cases sit in the 17-25%/yr band, against the ~4-5% a term deposit pays.

Income once keys land

Saadiyat gross yields today run indicatively **~6-7% on apartments and ~4.5-5.5% on villas** long-let - with the short-let premium on top for beach product (next page). Yield on ORIGINAL cost improves every year the district appreciates after entry.

Illustrations, not promises: growth cases are historical rates projected forward and may not repeat; exits before completion require developer NOC per SPA terms; selling costs, service charges and furnishing excluded. This is a frame for thinking, not a forecast.

Three Ways To Play It

1. **The Airbnb engine (Đ1.4M-4M tier).** Beachfront + five museums + Broadway at Gehry's Dar al Fanun + a superyacht marina = year-round short-let demand from culture tourists, performers, visiting academics and Dubai weekenders. Short-let is also untouched by Abu Dhabi's long-let rent cap - the regulatory tailwind nobody's discussing. The studio/1-bed tier doubles as the NYU rental market's premium end for stretches you choose to long-let.
2. **The trophy tier (Đ20M+).** 101-metre berths, Gehry frontage, the last beachfront villas on the cultural island - this is the thinnest supply and the global-wealth magnet. Liquidity is slower here, but scarcity is absolute: when Saadiyat's coast is done, it's done. The millionaire-migration data (Abu Dhabi's millionaire population +75% since 2013) is the demand side of this trade.
3. **The cycle trade (any tier).** Delivery 2030-33 lands the handover in the window where Abu Dhabi's cycle - currently running years behind Dubai's - matures. You're buying the capital's growth years with staged capital, at launch pricing, in its single most institutional district. The Chapter Seven maths is this lens in numbers.

One honest note on the rent cap: Abu Dhabi froze long-let rent increases at 0% from June 2026 (temporary, replacing the 5% cap). Long-let modellers should assume flat rents until policy changes; short-let and capital-growth strategies are unaffected - and it's precisely why lens 1 leads with Airbnb.

CHAPTER NINE

The Risks - Named, Not Hidden

RISK	REALITY	MITIGATION / STANCE
Long horizon	Delivery 2030-33: four to seven years of patience required.	Staged capital limits exposure; buy only with money that can wait; resale windows open per SPA thresholds.
Undisclosed detail	Masterplan ≠ price sheet. Mixes, phasing and pricing are unannounced - the event itself said so.	Everything here updates on release day; trigger rules decided in advance beat showroom decisions.
Island supply	18,000 homes is real supply, phased over years, alongside wider AD pipeline.	Absorption in AD is running hot (off-plan +156%/yr); phase-one buyers face the least completed competition.
Growth assumptions	Last year's +18.3% will not repeat forever; cycles cycle.	Chapter Seven's half-pace case is the planning number; the full-pace case is the upside, not the base.
Rail delivery	High-speed rail timelines are promises until they're stations.	Modelled at zero value throughout - pure upside if delivered.
Rent regulation	0% long-let cap active since June 2026.	Short-let unaffected; capital-growth thesis unaffected; assume flat long-let rents until policy shifts.

The biggest risk, as always: buying the brochure instead of the numbers - the wrong unit at a launch premium because the showroom was beautiful. Every launch has excellent value and terrible value on the same price sheet, usually one floor apart. Telling them apart on release day is the entire job.

HOW TO POSITION

Before The Price Sheet Exists

Launch allocation goes to the prepared: registered early, documents ready, budget proven, criteria decided on shore - not in a showroom. When Aldar opens the book, the best units go in hours.

The positioning sequence: 1) Decide your lens (Airbnb tier / trophy / cycle trade) and bracket now. 2) Documents launch-ready - passport, proof of funds. 3) Set trigger rules in advance: "if phase-one opens below Đ[X]/sqft, I'm in for Đ[Y]." 4) Be registered the day interest opens - I'll handle that. 5) Decide fast on allocation day with the criteria already written.

Message me and say you'd like a call on Marsa Al Saadiyat.

WhatsApp: **+971 55 350 2699**

Instagram: **@uaecalum**

Calum MacLeod · White & Co · Dubai & Abu Dhabi